



CPC 511: Psychology of Loss and Grief

School of Health and Social Sciences

Credits: 3

Grading Type: Decimal

Faculty Information

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For additional information, see the "Meet your Instructor" page in the course.

Course Catalog Description

This course examines the experience of grief and loss from a range of perspectives. Students will explore the varied ways that loss may be experienced, contended with, and integrated into one's worldview. Loss is inevitable; nothing and no one lasts forever. Learning to be with others who are in mourning (eg. death of a loved one or pet; loss of a meaningful relationship; loss of employment; loss of identity) is important for clinical counsellors. Awareness of the culturally diverse ways in which grief and mourning are experienced and expressed is also an essential area of competency for all practitioners.

Throughout CityU's Master of Counselling Program, students are encouraged to film themselves and review their counselling skills when working in dyads, triads or groups. Note that the consent of all participants involved must be acquired before any filming may proceed.

Consideration of Social Justice Issues

City University in Canada is committed to social justice, access, and inclusion. Throughout their studies in the Master of Counselling Program, students are invited to reflect on a range of social justice questions as follows:

- How does our own experience of privilege impact our ability to critically evaluate counselling theories and the provision of counselling services within the counselling field?
- What is the experience of racialized and othered individuals within counselling, e.g., are clients able to see themselves represented within their counsellor, or the counselling experience? Are indigenous healing practices acknowledged?
- Why do the majority of counselling theories represent the academic and research views of predominantly white, middle-class, European, male perspective? Which counselling theories break away from this dominant perspective, and how do they contribute to our overall understanding of working with cultures and identities that differ from our own?

Territorial Acknowledgement & Statement of Inclusion

City University in Canada (CityU) acknowledges and respects that we are on the traditional territories of First Nations, Metis, and Inuit Peoples. Each of our campuses

resides on a different territory, each with their own distinct languages, culture, and traditions. In the spirit of reconciliation and in respect of the diversity among nations, we would like to acknowledge the territories for each of our campuses.

We acknowledge that our Vancouver, British Columbia campus is located on the unceded and traditional territory of the Coast Salish Nations of xʷməθkʷəy̓əm (Musqueam), sə́lilwətaʔ (Tsleil-Waututh), and Skwxwú7mesh (Squamish) Peoples.

We acknowledge that our Southern Vancouver Island campus is located on the traditional and unceded territory of the Coast Salish Peoples of the Esquimalt, Songhees, and W̱SÁNEĆ Nations.

The lands that we at CityU are on hold the history and cultural traditions of many Indigenous Peoples. We recognize that Indigenous traditions, knowledge, and languages have been deeply damaged by the ongoing colonization of and biases against Indigenous Peoples. We acknowledge these territories with respect to their heritage and communities. With this acknowledgment, we are committed to begin building and maintaining respectful relationships with local Indigenous communities.

CityU honours human diversity in all its forms and is committed to the principle of universal human dignity. We further acknowledge that our learning community is greatly enriched through the voices and perspectives of staff, faculty, and students from all intersections of society including LGBTQ+, BIPOC and diversely-abled communities.

Course Resources

Required and recommended resources to complete coursework and assignments are found on the course [Reading List](#). The reading list can be found in the top navigation menu in Brightspace as well as from the library homepage.

Note: Required resources that must be purchased by the student are tagged “Purchase from a vendor of your choosing.” Required resources with a direct link, “Available through CityU Library”, are available at no cost to students.

Students in Canada will see required resources they need to purchase tagged “Purchase from the Canadian Bookstore.” Students outside the U.S. and Canada should contact their advisor or textbook coordinator for additional information.

Program Learning Outcomes

The content of this course aligns with the following Learning Outcomes:

PO 1 Counselling Skills: Apply sound essential Counselling skills derived from a credible knowledge base that encompasses diverse theoretical perspectives:

1.2 Diagnosis & Treatment: Develop informed diagnoses and appropriate, culturally-relevant treatment and risk mitigation plans.

1.1 Therapeutic Conversations: Facilitate therapeutic conversations that clarify the presenting problem and demonstrate empathy, active listening, attunement, and rapport-building skills.

1.3 Application: Synthesize and apply relevant counselling theories and frameworks in a culturally-competent manner when treating clients.

1.4 Client-Centered Care: Provide compassionate, client-centered care appropriate for the age, history, race/ethnicity, religion, culture, sexual orientation, intersectionality, social location and other unique contexts of the client(s).

1.5 Professional Boundaries: Establish and maintain professional boundaries.

Course Assignments and Grading

The grades earned for the course will be derived using CityU's decimal grading system, based on the following:

Overview of Required Assignments

Overview of Required Assignments	% of Final Grade
Research Paper: Cultural Aspects of Mourning	30%
Unique Topics in Grief Group Presentation	30%
Peer-Review Group Report	10%
Personal Grief Reflection Assignment	20%
Participation	10%
TOTAL	100%

Course Assignment Details

Research Paper: Cultural Aspects of Mourning (30%) - DUE Sunday, April 26

Students will write a research paper exploring mourning practices from a culture other than their own. Themes to consider include: 1) how the culture under investigation views death; 2) the meaning and significance given to death;

3) conceptualizations of the afterlife; 4) mourning rituals; 5) gendered responsibilities during periods of mourning; 6) public and private dimensions of mourning; 7) the clinical relevance of culture-bound mourning traditions; and 8) ethical considerations including risk assessment, and safety planning.

This paper must be 5 to 10 pages, double-spaced, using a minimum of 5 to 8 peer-reviewed and other cultural sources. APA formatting and citations are mandatory as the failure to cite sources appropriately constitutes plagiarism.

Papers are to be submitted in **WORD format**. If converting from another program to Word, **you may also upload a PDF** of your original **as an additional document**, which will be used to review APA formatting only.

Research Paper: Cultural Aspects of Mourning

Grading Criteria	Grade Points	% of Grade
Organization and Coherence	10 Points	10%
Evidence and Support	20 Points	20%
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	20 Points	20%
Professional Ethics	20 Points	20%
Cultural Competence	20 Points	20%
APA	10 Points	10%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Unique Topics in Grief Group Presentations (30%) - DUE May 8 & May 15

In groups of 3-4 (max 6 groups), students will research their chosen topic and create a group presentation for the class,

which includes the following elements:

- Theory/conceptualization of the unique features of this kind of grief
- Best practices and counselling approaches for this kind of grief
- Demonstration of an embodied practice, intervention, or ritual for this kind of grief **(this is the core of the presentation)**

Presentations will be a **max length 40 minutes each including 5 minutes for questions.**

Topics include:

- Infertility and infant loss
- Pet loss
- Relationship loss/heartbreak (including divorce and separation loss)
- Ambiguous loss for caregivers of the terminally ill
- Cultural grief
- Community loss/loss of sources of meaning
- Ecological grief
- Job/identity loss
- Anticipatory loss for those diagnosed with a terminal illness

Students are welcome to suggest other topics.

There is no requirement that every group member present equally or present at all. It is up to you as a group to ensure that there is space for everyone to contribute in whatever way makes sense individually, for your group, and for the class. If some group members are not presenting, consider how you can ensure that everyone's contribution is acknowledged and made visible to others. What is most important is that you collaborate as a group.

Unique Topics in Grief Group Presentation

Grading Criteria	Grade Points	% of Grade
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Grading Criteria	Grade Points	% of Grade
Organization and Coherence	20 Points	20%
Evidence and Support	20 Points	20%
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	10 Points	10%
Demonstration (practice, intervention, ritual)	20 Points	20%
Cultural Competence (acknowledge cultural elements of demo)	20 Points	20%
APA	10 Points	10%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Peer Review Group Report (10%) - DUE May 8 & May 15

Peer review is a core academic activity in which colleagues support one another's professional development by offering feedback on each other's scholarly work. Instructors will inform students of the specific guidelines for this assignment. Students will be reviewing each group presentation on both presentation days. These reviews will be done in-class using a template provided by the Instructor.

Peer-Review Group Report

Grading Criteria	Grade Points	% of Grade
Organization and Coherence	10 Points	10%
Evidence and Support	20 Points	20%
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	20 Points	20%
Evaluating Information	20 Points	20%
Self-reflection	20 Points	20%
APA	10 Points	10%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Personal Grief Reflection Assignment (20%) - DUE Sunday, June 14

Students will complete a reflection assignment that explores their own experiences of grief and loss.

Students will design and engage in the traditional practice of a communal grief ritual of their own choosing. Students may choose whoever they feel is most appropriate to act as their community witness/co-mourner and however many people they like (a 1-1 interaction, small group of friends, or a large ceremony); these may be class members, friends, family, etc., whoever the student genuinely feels they can engage with authentically. The source of the grief is fully determined by the student based on their own experiences of grief and loss (examples include the death of a loved one, a pet, the loss of a relationship of any kind, the loss of a piece of identity, a major life transition such as moving or cultural identity shift, grief regarding the experience of having to cut off or hide a cherished part of self to fit into mainstream society or family culture, a connection to cultural grief, or grief related to ecological degradation and loss).

The ritual is to be fully created and determined by the student. Examples could include: simply hosting a grief share conversation, an exchange of poetry or spoken word, a communal art-making experience, an embodied ritual such as laying stones in the river, burying objects that represent your sorrow, writing a letter and putting it in the fire, singing, drumming, etc.

This assignment will identify ways that students' personal grief may influence their therapeutic collaboration with a grieving client. Areas of potential countertransference will be examined and strategies to mitigate countertransference will clearly articulated.

Students will submit their reflections on their experience in the form of a traditional 6 - 8-page, APA paper or in an alternative format such as blogging, podcasts, Wikis, expressive arts modalities etc.

Personal Grief Reflection Assignment

<i>Grading Criteria</i>	Grade Points	% of Grade
Organization and Coherence	10 Points	10%
Personal Philosophy	20 Points	20%
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	20 Points	20%
Professional Ethics	20 Points	20%
Cultural Competence	20 Points	20%
Self-reflection	10 Points	10%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Participation (10%) - Self Assessment DUE Sunday, June 14

A collaborative learning environment is something that is co-created by all participants. How you prepare for, show up for, engage in, and reflect on classes impacts the learning experience of your peers, as well as your own. The coursework and in-class activities are designed to develop clinical competencies, and your thoughtful attendance, preparation, and engagement are essential to the creation of a vibrant learning community.

Safety is cultivated through respectful engagement amongst peers and with the instructor, and through adherence to strict confidentiality. You are responsible for developing and maintaining awareness about what has shaped you to this moment, what you carry with you into each class, and what is showing up for you throughout the course. Reflexivity is a core competency in counselling practice and how you practice this in class is important preparation for

professional practice. Consider when it is useful to bring your own voice forward, and when it may be more useful to hold space for others. Being able to invite in curiosity when there are different perspectives contributes to safety and will serve you well in future practice.

At the end of the course, students will use the Participation Self Assessment Template provided to complete a self assessment of their participation in alignment with the template criteria. This self-assessment is an exercise in ethics. The instructor may adjust the self-ratings to address any oversights.

Note: *Additional learning activities **may be assigned** by the instructor for students that are absent. This will depend on the day missed. It is up to the student to request the opportunity for additional learning activities.*

Participation

Grading Criteria	Grade Points	% of Grade
Participation	100	100%
TOTAL	100	100%

REQUIRED TEXTS:

Harris, D. L., & Winokuer, H. R. (2019). *Principles and practice of grief counseling* (3rd ed.). Springer.

Hochstetler, L. (2021). *21 days to die: The Canadian guide to end of life*. Sumeru Press.

Neimeyer, R. A., Harris, D. L., Winokuer, H. R., & Thornton, G. F. (2011). *Grief and bereavement in contemporary society: Bridging research and practice*. Routledge.

NOTE: *Course schedule will be posted in a separate document on Brightspace.*

Course Policies

Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Academic integrity is not upheld when: "Utilizing generative artificial intelligence without guidance from a faculty member to write a paper, produce code, or generate any other required course assignment without proper citation." Specific guidance on AI usage for this course will be provided by the instructor.

Late Assignments

Graduate students are expected to submit all assignments by the due dates stated in the syllabus. A late assignment is one that is submitted after the due date and time or after any extension has expired.

If circumstances prevent a student from meeting the due date, students should contact the instructor and request an extension at least 48 hours prior to the date the assignment is due. Emergency situations will be considered on a case-by-case basis. Being busy, pressured with outside work, or having competing academic commitments are not usually considered valid reasons to receive extensions.

A student who receives an extension in advance of the due date and abides by the agreement with the instructor is not subject to late penalties. The guideline for late penalties is a deduction of one point per day from the overall grade for the first 10 days and 5 points per day after 10 days. Instructors may vary these guidelines in response to the specific conditions and requirements of each course. In the absence of an alternative announced by the Instructor the default policy is the general guideline cited above. Assignments may

be re-written only with the express consent of the Instructor and under exceptional circumstances.

Participation

All MC courses encourage active engagement in discussion, dialogue, role plays and similar exercises in order to receive the maximum educational benefits. Participation includes constructive criticism and the negotiation of different perspectives and ideas. Recognizing that there are many forms of participation a range of forms and styles are welcomed. Active engagement means being attentive. Similarly, it is recognized that there are situations in which learning to hold one's counselor to not participate verbally are valuable learning experiences.

Consistent attendance and a willingness to be actively involved in classroom discussions, small group activities, and at times classroom presentations or role plays assists in creating a vibrant learning community.

Many MC courses include a participation component and, in some cases, assignments specify that participation will be graded. In such cases the criteria for participation will be made known along with the requirements for grade achievement.

Professional Writing

Assignments require error-free writing that uses standard English conventions and logical flow of organization to address topics clearly, completely, and concisely. CityU requires the use of APA style.

University Policies

Students are responsible for understanding and adhering to all of CityU's academic policies. The most current versions of these policies can be found in the [University Catalog](#) that is linked from the CityU Web site.

Non-Discrimination & Prohibition of Sexual Harassment

City University of Seattle, its staff and its faculty are deeply committed to supporting our students. We value equity, diversity, and inclusion as a way of life as well as for the educational opportunities it provides. CityU will not tolerate any form of discrimination based on race, color, ethnicity, sexual orientation, gender identification, socioeconomic status, or religious values. Any student who has experienced discrimination based on the above criteria is encouraged to report this to the University. Students may report an experience of discrimination to their course instructor. If they do not feel safe reporting to their instructor, students may report an experience of discrimination directly to the university Provost or the Vice President of Student Affairs.

CityU adheres to all federal, state, and local civil rights laws prohibiting discrimination in employment and education. The University is committed to ensuring that the education environment is bounded by standards of mutual respect and safety and is free from discriminatory practices.

In Canada, in compliance with the British Columbia Human Rights Code, the Alberta Human Rights Act, WorksafeBC, and the Workers' Compensation Board of Alberta, the University believes that its environment should at all times

be supportive and respectful of the dignity and self-esteem of individuals. Discrimination, harassment and bullying conduct, whether through person-to-person behaviour or via electronic communications such as email or social media is not acceptable and will not be tolerated. As an educational institution, it is our responsibility to cultivate an environment of excellence, equity, mutual respect and to recognize the value and potential of every individual. The University will take all necessary steps to meet or exceed the requirements of the law to prevent discrimination, harassment and bullying. Information on the prevention of discrimination, harassment and bullying can be found at [Canada's Respectful Workplace Policy](#).

Religious Accommodations

CityU has a policy for accommodation of student absences or significant hardship due to reasons of faith or conscience, or for organized religious activities. The University's policy, including more information about how to request an accommodation, is available in the University Catalog and on the my.cityu.edu student portal. Accommodations must be requested by the 20% mark of this course (e.g. day 14 of a ten-week course, day 7 of a 5-week course) using the Religious Accommodations Request Form found on the student dashboard in the my.cityu.edu student portal.

Academic Integrity Academic integrity in students requires the pursuit of scholarly activity that is free from fraud, deception and unauthorized collaboration with other individuals. Students are responsible for understanding CityU's policy on academic integrity and adhering to its standards in meeting all course requirements. A complete copy of this policy can be found in the [University Catalog](#) under Student Rights and Responsibilities on the page titled Academic Integrity Policy.

Attendance

Students taking courses in any format at the University are expected to be diligent in their studies and attend class regularly. Regular class attendance/contact is important in achieving learning outcomes in the course and correlates in many cases with participation. As such it may be a valid consideration in determining the final grade. At the beginning of each course, the instructor will inform students of the relevance of class attendance/contact to the final grade.

Attendance in this class is vital to learning the required course material and demonstrates professionalism and respect for fellow students and the instructor. All students are required to attend every class for the full duration of the class. Arriving late or leaving early will constitute an unexcused absence. It is expected that students who will not be attending or who will be arriving late notify the instructor before class starts.

Excused absences are limited to ILLNESS OR EMERGENCY. Absences related to illness may require verification from a medical doctor. All other absences will be considered unexcused.

In the event of inclement weather, students will be notified by a CityU representative and / or faculty of site closures. As student and faculty safety is a priority, students who feel that driving conditions are unsafe will be permitted an excused absence without penalty. Students are responsible for notifying the instructor before class starts that they will not be attending class due to inclement weather.

Students with more than 2 unexcused absences will be directed to meet with the local Program Director to discuss

continued participation in the course. 3% of students' overall course grade will be deducted for each unexcused absence.

A complete copy of CityU's policy can be found in the [University Catalog](#) under Student Rights and Responsibilities on the page titled Attendance.

Final Assignment Due Date

Final assignments for each class at CityU must be due on or before the final date of the course as indicated in the university's course information system. Due dates that extend beyond the final date of the course may negatively impact tuition funding for students.

Support Services

Disability Services Accommodations Statement

Students with a need for academic accommodation for disability, pregnancy, or religious reasons are encouraged to contact the Student Accommodation Office to discuss accommodation requests and eligibility requirements. Please contact the Student Accommodation Services at accommodations@cityu.edu or 206.239.4751 or visit the [accommodations support page](#) in the my.cityu.edu portal or in the Start Your Course Here module in your course under Support Services.

Confidentiality will be observed in all inquiries. Once approved, information about academic accommodations will be shared with course instructors.

Mental Health and Wellness Resources

In this complex and evolving world, your mental health matters. Discover the different resources available to

support your well-being.

Empower Me is a confidential mental health and wellness service, is available 24/7, 365 days a year. This service is complimentary for all CityU students in Canada. Visit [Empower Me](#) for more information.

For students attending in Canada but temporarily located outside of Canada, Empower Me is available through the Dialogue mobile app or platform (maximum of 90 days). Access [Dialogue](#) to create your account and get started.

CityU's Counselling Clinics offer free counselling services in a convenient format. To learn more, visit the [Counselling Clinics](#) web page.

Healthmind Clinic is an integral part of City University in Canada. A not-for-profit institution with a rich legacy of training exceptional counsellors for over 25 years, Healthmind offers a safe and inclusive environment to access counselling support and innovative clinical training, supervision and education. Visit [Healthmind Clinic](#) for more information.

Here2Talk is a valuable resource for students in British Columbia. A virtual counselling service, Here2Talk provides free mental health support to students via an app, over the phone, or through online chat. Experienced professionals provide support 24/7 and no appointment is needed. Visit [Here2Talk](#) for more information.

For **Federal and Provincial Government support services**, visit the [Other Mental Health Resources](#) web page.

Library Services

CityU librarians are available to help students find the resources and information they need to succeed in this

course. Contact a CityU librarian through the [Ask a Librarian](#) service, or access [library resources and services online](#), 24 hours a day, seven days a week.

Online Tutoring

CityU students have access to free online tutoring offered through Brainfuse, including writing support, from certified tutors 24 hours a day, seven days a week. For more information visit the [Brainfuse](#) page on the [my.cityu.edu](#) portal.

Sensitive Content Notice

Because the counselling profession is designed to explore the inner life of individuals, certain content discussed in CityU's Master of Counselling courses may be emotionally activating for students. The university's goal is to empower students to practice active self-care throughout their time in the program. Active self-care is an ethical responsibility for those in self-regulating professions and assists clinicians in successfully meeting clients in spaces where emotionally sensitive content is present. Similarly, in the Master of Counselling program, an ethic of care for the self is a critical consideration.

Emotionally sensitive content involves a wide variety of topics including, but not limited to, abuse, assault, neglect, self-harm, identity, sexuality, appearance, misogyny, classism, racialized issues, colonization, religious practices, trauma, grieving, ageism, caregiving, and physical or mental health. Students are encouraged to carefully attend to their emotional wellbeing when reading, listening to, viewing, or participating in course activities involving sensitive content.

It is important to note that exploring sensitive content is an inherent part of the counselling profession. However, the

complexity of human experience means students' personal histories may become activated to the point that effective learning is no longer feasible. In such cases, students are encouraged to prioritize balancing their emotional wellbeing with their professional growth. This may be done through timely self-reflection and communication with instructors and/or peers about the self-regulation strategies students will implement while engaging sensitive content.

As part of their professional growth, students are also encouraged to pursue personal counselling related to sensitive content explored in the program. Personal counselling deepens students' learning and provides insight into their future clients' experiences of the therapeutic process. Additional resources available to students include the Empower Me Program, Self-Care folders in Brightspace, and local campus wellness initiatives.

Master of Counselling's Professional Code

In addition to City University's general student code of conduct located in the Registrar's City U Calendar, counselling students are further expected to conduct themselves in a manner that is consistent with the core values of the profession they are entering. Students will be encouraged to adopt the following behaviours and are accountable to their peers, faculty, and CityU to sincerely undertake the development of these hallmarks of maturity:

1. Respect the dignity of classmates, faculty, and administrators without prejudice in all forms of behaviour and communication in matters of race, religion, skin colour, ethnicity, gender, orientation, physical presentation, age, ancestry or birthplace. This includes, but is not limited to, standing up against

- and/or reporting behaviours such as bullying, scapegoating, gossip, slander etc.
2. Maintain a positive approach to managing course-related, administrative, or relationship challenges in line with the core values of the profession. This includes, but is not limited to, directly approaching specific individuals regarding concerns of note and attempting to collaborate and independently problem-solve prior to involving faculty or administrators in the matter. Students who feel unable to independently resolve the issue should seek the support of cohort representatives, faculty, or staff.
 3. Demonstrate exemplary personal conduct consistent with the values of the profession including integrity, accountability, reflexivity, generosity, compassion, inclusiveness, honesty, courage, maturity, thoughtfulness, good judgment, patience, and fairness. Demonstrate a commitment to modelling the standards and ethics of the counselling profession in all aspects of personal conduct in both the university and community at large.
 4. Access City University's campuses or resources ONLY with approval from an authorized representative of the university.
 5. Recognize that students with formal academic accommodations are expected to meet the same academic standards as their peers with the help of additional supports and reasonable, penalty free extensions.
 6. Recognize that consistent face-to-face and online class attendance is a basic, non-negotiable requirement of the program and that the program's attendance policies will be enforced without exception. Students who are absent for any reason are required to make up all instructional hours and assignments at the discretion of the instructor.
 7. Ensure that all requests for assignment extensions (with and without accommodations) are submitted to faculty a minimum of 48 hours in advance of the assignment due date. Extensions may not be granted after assignment due dates have passed.
 8. Respect and behave in accordance with the appropriate professional boundaries inherent in faculty, administrative, and evaluative roles.

9. As an ambassador for the City University program, conduct themselves in a manner that strengthens the reputation of the profession, one's peers, and the program.
10. Actively develop and practice the core counselling skills of attunement, presence, and empathy in all program-related interpersonal interactions.
11. Respond to feedback from faculty and administrators in ways that facilitate personal growth, preserve our collaborative learning environment, and reflect the standards of the counselling profession.
12. Balance enthusiastic contributions to classroom discussion with ensuring there is sufficient space for all voices to be heard. This involves actively staying aware of the dynamics of class discussions and actively encouraging everyone's participation.
13. Commit to active course participation that contributes to one's own and others learning.
14. Embrace both positive and challenging academic learning opportunities and consider how these experiences can be applied in the service of personal and professional growth.